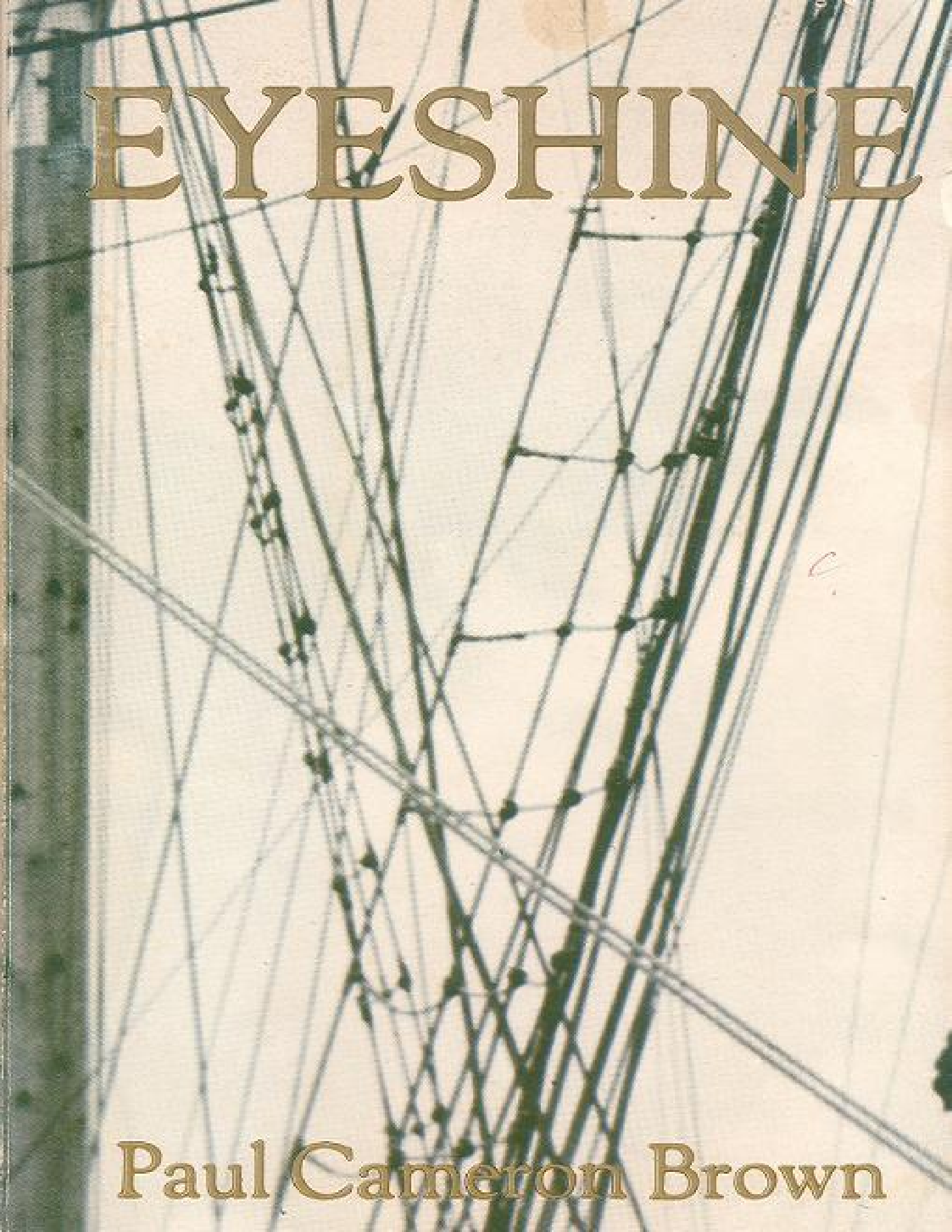
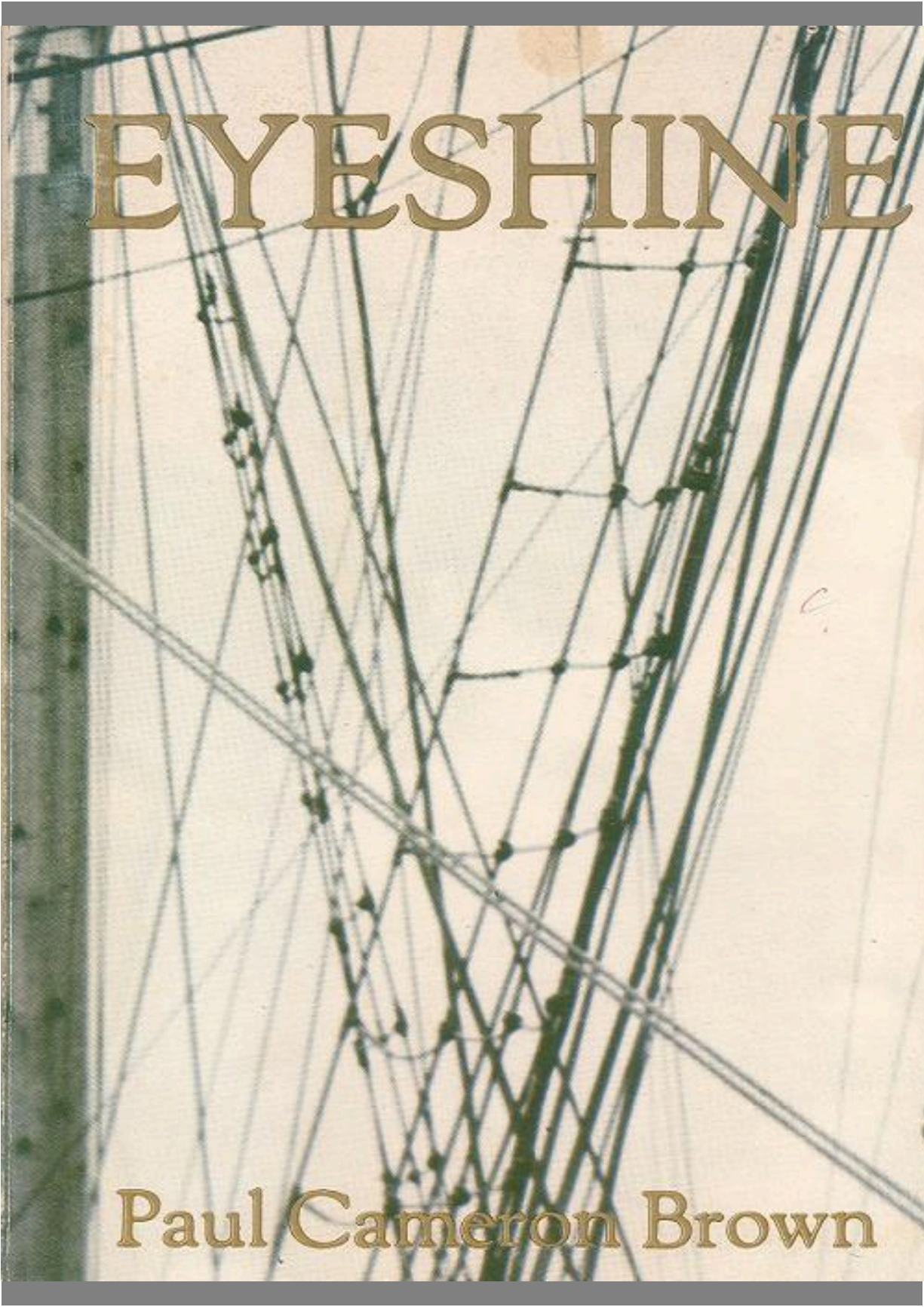


The background of the cover is a photograph of a ship's mast and its intricate rigging. The mast is a dark, vertical structure, and the rigging consists of numerous ropes and pulleys that create a complex web of lines across the frame. The lines are dark against a light, slightly hazy sky. The overall composition is dynamic, with many diagonal lines from the rigging intersecting the vertical mast.

# EYESHINE

Paul Cameron Brown



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# **EYESHINE**

**By**  
**Paul Cameron Brown**

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## STILLNESS

Invitingly, the sea shines her stars,  
captive flames within an impatient heart  
as darkness loads the pleasant isles with coarseness,  
slow sparks rise over a roaring fire.

And strolling beaches near dawn  
when the sand fleas & crabs are seen to flee,  
one catches upon the imperfect stillness  
a song of one - wind with sea  
drawing near  
inward, such stars turn  
as bonds at last  
worked free.

[\[7\]](#).

## HEWANORRA

The moon, at most a shudder or two away.  
The sky, bivouaked and cloudy, is within twin sloops of a bay.  
The lagoon opens, spars with the greater ocean  
by island hopping, green azure blue, as  
the wind steps before an open sea.

The great ridge of the mountain  
lies obscured by rain;  
jasmine, frequent colour  
and plantations  
with cocoa, soursop, and cinnamon.

Arawaks, Pelee,



Carriacoi, Anegada,  
Josephine of the Creoles,  
let Admiral Rodney atone Lord Byng.

And my Patois beauty,  
breath laced Oleander sweet -  
take the hemming from your dress  
then come sit down with me.

[8]

## THE INTRUDER

The colouring of spacious flowers rove delicious to the eye.  
The road above the harbour fickle, carousing in its tendency  
to pull too gray by sky enamelled water.

The tropical foliage, still and languorous, to my touch.  
Each particle of sunlight dangling as if hoisted from  
a perfumed ledge.

Newly mown grass in streaks, browns serpent-like across  
the path.

Low erogenous puffs of dust are swathed by passing feet.  
Near by, bushes wear the foliage of streaked mud as a mantle  
might cottonwool at Christmas.

Life in such climes is built on connotations rather than pure  
innuendoes of purpose.

The southern sky, the heat above the sea allude to this.  
This triumphant trilogy embossed upon volcanic slate, more  
crumpled paper than firm land.

Gravesides lying in twilight nakedness.

The scion moon in her damaged vestry between acolyte  
clouds.

Hamlets resembling clotted blood, nicks across an earmarked  
horizon.

The poor, wavering to transfixed in their hotly owned sun;  
the one commodity they rightly possess.

The outpouring sea, loosing herself in bridged inlets,  
countless points that nudge the land in acknowledged  
supremacy.

The irrelevance of time, inbreeding of pale intruder.

## DINNER AT EIGHT

At times, I thought of swizzling white rum  
in the tropics (not as a vocation),  
dropping into the club  
for a round of tennis  
before dinner at eight  
or a quiet set of darts  
before retiring.

I had grown accustomed to my new routine  
(at least vicariously).  
In the best Somerset Maugham tradition  
I would dress for dinner,  
decline to be patronizing,  
avoid the potential slur  
if crisp linen did not appear  
regularly on my bed or table.  
I still found time to stop  
for breakfast coffee,  
take a moment from regimen  
to fondle fresh, wet flowers,  
look over the balcony at the  
blueness of the bay.

The metaphysical qualities that come  
into play erode such morning somnambulations.  
The heat depreciated any vainglorious  
attempts to lionize the native Caribbean rum.  
Tennis and darts become ho-hum,  
more of a task than a pleasant diversion.  
The little yellowed board seemed  
to symbolize not convivial cordiality  
but crabbed provincialism.

The tie & collar were intolerable  
against the saline tropic night and  
seemed rigid in a place and time  
the locals could not possibly share.  
In short, such things celebrated my apartness.

Linen rarely, if ever, appeared



and to resort to complaints  
resulted in only furthering  
the distance between one and his hosts.  
Even the coffee tasted bitter and seemed  
unsuited to the needs of an interloper.  
Neither was fruit juice the promised manna.  
And one can take only so much nostalgic flower warbling.  
The hummingbirds and oleander came to grow  
as commonplace and exhausting as the rain.

I began ruminating thoughts back to my previous existence.  
Surprised at my illogical shift in allegiances,  
I began stealing thoughts more and more surreptitiously  
about the naturalness of working a full day,  
donning the apparel of a civilized man,  
dropping the white man's burden.  
Disgust filled me with my former Rousseauian yearnings.  
With trepidation, one's dreams  
can erect barriers more effective  
than the most ill-sponsored illusions.

[\[10\]](#)

## THE BAY OF CORTES

The sea is a requisitioned article in my possession.  
Above, in fat circles of conformity, glide  
turkey vultures, their combs  
a rich obscenely red.

The guano rocks are isles and stepping stones  
of bird waste.  
They lie thick and bedeviled with fish fur,  
a dull lavender cached hard to the sun  
seems to shine a metallic harvest white  
as desert rocklets scattered to the breeze.

A speck of a fisherman dots the horizon.  
His craft a barque in loneliness across the sea.  
Dolphins inveigh the richness of the depths,  
persuade latitudes to drift about their wake.  
Pelicans sour the parabola distances between light and sound,  
become chancy over this distant breath of song.

Above the cliffs and the inner roads that follow  
the desert into geometric squares, stand abodes.  
The thin supremacy of shadows at dusk disparage the  
traveller here.

Burros strayed lie dead by the highway's edge.  
The liquid depth of the mountains reinforces vulnerability.  
The night air is alive with the torment of insects, asplash  
with sound.

Lights carry an eerie message dotted about the hills.  
Feeling alone is a delicacy to be savoured by the standards  
of the tropic sun.

[\[12\]](#)

## ORACABESSA

An iron wrought gate of turpentine force conveys little pigment,  
almost black parchment letters mindful of  
hands, arched and stroked from the very stone, until an  
elephantine water runs nettle sand to their granite perch.  
The broiling heat in this part of the Indies one knows must,  
posthaste, carry to the humus and flies any modicum of  
human remains.

And, over distant dispatch of time, the elongated sprawl of  
waves dashing up straight to the shallow's grave, makes  
memory drawn, any record of the little parish's dead flimsy  
in the topsy context of soil and undulant peat.

A greened isle stares past the feckless scene, past again an  
aged church noticeboard that scrapes out traces of news  
worthy of import to the wormy road.

Whitewash, the colour of the shackled crypts, casts upon  
the church a pallor of distraught gray.

A goat is seen foraging between such marker stones.  
The day seems to cut into the marble white detachment  
of the sarcophagi with abrupt candor.

Yet, while the cove pokes like a walking stick, the sun &  
earth conspire to reclaim this space as their rightful bread.

A huge vegetative urge to growth is witness to abundant  
further life - life in whorls of bamboo shoot, naseberry  
thatches & canebreak all garnished a short stride across the  
barrier gate.

[\[13\]](#).

## PROSPECTUS

In salt flats,  
idle pools  
bunching off the ocean,  
multi-legged crabs, worsted stalks -  
sea crimson weed  
weigh the panoply  
to heighten my deepening fervour.

In the bedrock shanks  
of spread tidal basins  
clothed in spools of enveloping  
brackish water,  
a plethora teeming with aqua towns  
and untold gadgetry exists -  
replete with mimicry  
including primeval  
flotilla tanks  
and broadsheets for spreading  
their way of life.

[\[14\]](#).

## GLADIATORS

No broken visor, emptied glove  
abandoned cudgel, opened net  
- only gathering spots on spreading sand.

Clang of cymbals  
wrench of flesh,  
death is a morsel  
delectably met.

[\[15\]](#).

# OCEAN SEA

All that is eternal is circular.  
- Aristotle

Cueta and Tetuan are outposts within the Arab psyche,  
frail islets jutting their Islamic consciousness  
into the infidel mind.

A mere eight miles separates the tip of North Africa  
from Iberia's reclining form.

An Arab dhow sits off the port of Tangier  
where the unsuspecting can lose more than priapic curiosity.

Arabia, from Ormuz to Sofala,  
an empire of sabulous plenitude -  
shiekdoms, oil rich fiefs, and  
luxurious enervation.

Da Gama rounds the Bight of Africa, needles the Saracen eye.

Tutankhamen rests dolefully within the dunes  
away from bone merchants until 1923 draws nigh.

Ptolemy errs and extends Africa to the Poles.

The noblest failure in antiquity rests in Zama  
while Jesus toiled for our betterment at Galilee.

Richard dies besieging Acre.

Carnage occurred at Lepanto with attendant demise of the Turk.

Marco Polo ignores the Levant for the riches of a Khan.

The memory of El Alamein burnt away any vestige of Tobruk.

The Casbah is my twain that confirms East & West shall never  
meet.

The False Prophet is in abundance, notwithstanding  
Western civilization's fierce resistance to his ideas.

Minarets, prayer rugs face Mecca five times daily while  
opium on a mother's breast induces premature death in  
unwanted infant girls.

The purdah is an eerie monologue between the feminine  
form and purloined courage.

Mysticism juxtaposes carnal delight in the halls of the  
Saladein's concubines.

Harems & the seraglios are the coveted date wine.

In Cape Bojador, there lurks a primeval instinct,  
a nagging supposition all is not right with Araby.

The bath, the cloying sweetness of duplicity,  
stirs amidst trenchant eyes.

Marmelukes are more than adventure book fiction  
in the silent quarters.

The swirling dust, the prohibition of alcoholic drink,  
are dervishes in the hadji's brain.

Everywhere, the ragged people cluster,  
almsgiving becomes a prayer in the saline night.

Any but the Moslem faith caught in the pilgrimmage  
to Mecca meet swift death.

The shopfronts with their bronzed clatter,  
decantered gold, near haggling that becomes  
the economics of plea bargaining, wits  
desire against pressing need.

Debarking from Algeciras, facing the sublime North African  
desert as her colours coil, pitch forward amongst the hills,  
squares this continent's personality against the Occident.

Europe found other continents soft butter to her trenchant  
blade.

Here, she must consider herself matched with the heady dictates  
of survival.

# COLD PASSION

Some dead undid undid their bushy jaws,  
and bags of blood let out their flies...  
Dylan Thomas

The land is barren  
wears straw wisps  
as an unkempt man  
might razor stubble.

The land is dry, a faded yellow  
in its barrenness.  
A sky broods from afar,  
a stalactite sun accounts merely a jot  
above that thin road into despair.

Grass lies everywhere dead,  
faded tongues above an  
earth afflicted with scleroderma,  
deadliest of skin disturbances,  
forerunner of deeper pestilence.

An erasing wind whips the fields  
further into bereavement;  
turns tiny bits of chaff to pursue themselves  
in a mad St. Vitus dance  
of cold passion.

Starry night. With halos  
about the moon, pale and languid, big as crimson,  
far as wind driven flax.

The orange pallor, pale  
with liquid swoon and ability  
to churn itself about the  
night sky or flood in endless  
beams our poorer spectacle below.

[\[19\]](#)

# FOR TOM THOMSON

I have thrust my fists  
up to ice in the  
galactic mire of lake,  
lured my minnow wriggler  
eyes as bait to ensnare  
inroads, lake bed wreaths,  
across the windchill spine of  
brooding heart.

I am on the essence of the North  
where latitudes of cold spontaneity  
remind me the nameless lakes  
part not easily with their secrets.

A man's bones go easily to rot  
in the frigid perspiration  
called primeval ooze,  
precambrian sweat,  
the tertiary stage syphilitic crawl  
of advancing ice.

All those terms your detractors, analyzers,  
devotees coin to define you: the Boreal,  
taiga, subarctic steppes, white hell,  
recoil under the onslaught, the lustrate message straining  
up alkaline clear.

Water is your blood.  
A vast hoarding, most of this  
planet's fresh drink  
is flushed through your  
bowels, with kidneys  
separating the renic  
qualities as snow and  
sleet, the night side of  
your character.

Tom, son of Thomson fame,  
his little canoe immeshed  
as scrubbed floorboards now,  
a giant winnowing such scattered  
firewood over a slow crop of  
putrefying muck; perhaps  
I see your eyes  
as sturdy bubbles  
popping from legions  
of green liquid  
to carouse with your



firm memory.

[\[21\]](#)

## THE WOODSMAN

Barely annoying the woods,  
his cabin like our woodpile  
home now for chipmunks and birds,  
isolated by the lily pads -  
he eschewed all comfort.

The view barely cognizant,  
the prospect of the Massasauga rattler  
and an occasional broken tin  
sharp at the edges  
was like water's drift  
audible, not yet seen.

Toying with the cove,  
past island jetties  
& blueberry groves  
inside little giant's tomb;  
this man became ingratiated with lake treasure,  
his clearing a triumphant blast.  
He affixed his mark -  
blazoning human habitation  
on a lonely spot.

[\[23\]](#)

## EAST OF OSWEGOE

Ticonderoga to Lake George,  
the classic invasion route  
up the Richelieu valley  
past Plattsburg,  
Verdun,  
à Montréal

across the North Shore  
reroute again  
  
to savour Albany;  
last of the trading posts east of Oswego  
before New York  
protective sanctuary  
lodgings,  
free from the scalping knife  
barrens and  
the horrors Fenimore Cooper described.

Apple crisp, fall damp the air  
with an unbroken stretch of forest  
and Adirondack mountains,  
there, delicate slip  
of fair womanhood  
bliss, she lies, gentle as the finger lakes  
clothed in autumn crimson.

[\[24\]](#).

## PRESENCE OF MIND

Spring heralds the summer with lilacs perched from that door.

In snows, a swarm of bushes lie black and apparently  
rootless as the town's iron-gate bridge collapses under the  
centre part of the main road.

Little enclaves of activity pass as stores,  
mere centrefolds across busy highway arteries this time  
of year.

I am a grey fleck in my dark wool coat near the perimeter  
of a winding fence.

The casual observer gives me half a chance to be seen in  
the deathless white, opaque coloured moonstone so still  
against the field's shores.

A plaster river, her sides inserted with isle-dotted chunks,  
hands across a winter solstice tribal dance.

Ostensibly, I poke the land from stylized limbo,  
a chalky substance disturbed with every movement's cough.

And if I were to fall, lie down, and cry,  
the agonized winter's frantic sun  
would bury me with shadows,  
give forth dark branches to my freedom.  
In the growing dark, I ponder white and infinity.  
The hectic pace of the distant highway absorbs  
less and less my hope.  
In private cold, my face burns a tallow white,  
toes flake in frostbite or erode every sensation.

Stars in the dark canopy above are cryptic mourners and  
people frigid sorrow.

Black is my colour as I ebb steadily toward their heights.

By morning, when the first wisp of straw or dry leaf  
catches light near this stringent fence, an occasional  
passerby with the presence of mind shall comment how  
lifeless fields are in the clutch of brittle snow.

[\[25\]](#)

## FISHING NETS

The polar stars drip in blood . . .  
Orion's mythical crystal white  
with clarity of forest and  
low expanse of sky;  
wooden barques, incandescent,  
row peals of silver light  
sowing each slough of wave,  
spider hues drip upon wetness  
forlorn with tug and rein.

[\[27\]](#)

## rites of intensification

Did time on the Hegelian  
spirit, Freudian id,  
the totemic response to  
the unknowable  
where each phenomenon of nature  
became dream time itself,  
the electric crackle  
of God's Voice-  
movement from shadowy spectre to  
tight-lipped showmanship  
the learned empathy  
of tires careening around  
their throttled load.

[\[28\]](#)

## JAGGED WIRE

A rail fence is more than that on a country dawn  
moving by lots over hill & stone;  
it barely pauses in the small of the field's lap,  
then is caught in grey positioning as  
light unfurls the sky.

All is a matter of perfect blistering -  
dauber wasps are seen to heave the moistened wood  
in chunks to mossy furrows, benign  
in their firm embrace upon alabaster trees.  
There, crusts of heavy nails, marked  
like fortresses, droop in their rusty mail.  
Mostly ants, in open canter, move  
in as upon an urn & lance far more  
than jagged wire the breath of stillest air.

[\[29\]](#)

## EYESHINE

I remember the world like a picture.  
The habitat of trees and sense impressions,  
the cover of leaves as fall spurred its way  
thru corridors of plasma forest & sarsen stone.

Most of all, I saw illuminated clearly  
the brash self poke of logic that came  
massively when sunlight stirred, lilted  
its early head erasing the world thru  
sand crusts of colour.

The cabin floor, a cold dawn infinity,  
was a chilblain on frosty morning shadows -  
the old cupboards staring like flowers  
through a break in the leaves  
watched till the latches & hinges were worlds  
in frozen power, dark rust as thoughts  
meandering like age.

The stamped down clay, the well worn earthen crust  
that met the door on opening showed  
the erring calender all its interminable  
days that waited, like madmen, to remind one of oceanic  
time.

And, on wakening, the careless passage  
of life across speckled windows saw a terrain of light -  
tiny works in agility, the forest  
looming bright as meridians  
off ladders bristling with homuncular forms.  
Door of caring, the gentle trail  
left as a universe to announce  
the brittle thrust and restive eves  
of daytime shadow.

[\[30\]](#)

## SWEET WATER

The leaves lie hidden as spades about their home.  
Brief movement of a kitten, then silence  
till the car's engine drones.  
Close by, a pioneer cemetery sits near a secondary wood.

Queer is the effect of sun on a tinted roof;  
bluebells with poppies,  
cowslip and tiny brook  
back of  
fields redden and  
given to wheat.

A house is a machine  
processing the water of living  
a replenished cistern,  
birds paying a call, a minor animal  
brushing past  
an ivy-railed fence.

[.\[32\].](#)

## PRIMAVERA

A poem is perishable and,  
like it,  
so much of life is spent  
in intervals -  
the jarring second  
regaining consciousness,  
a post-mortem flick  
of the lank equestrian eyelid  
that signals morning's first crepuscular move.

... a little salad consciousness  
about the tumescent room  
with the sentient purr of a cat;  
her musky oils  
a green verdure  
lapping primordial scent  
to engross a little readiness  
as the day progresses  
to its Oedipal stage  
and arrested development.

[.\[33\].](#)

# THE ENCOUNTER

Today surprised me  
like a red fox blurting  
out of an October thicket -  
empty, dry, the burst of its  
energy camouflaged much as  
that fox, solemn and cold,  
biding his time  
till he thought I  
passed.

[\[34\]](#)

# MAGPIE TONGUES

Trillium breath, an ounce  
of feathered growth unravels  
in the cloves of the silent forest.  
The rain is heavy with the stamp  
of perfumed trees realizing  
slight restraint on bursting seed.

Cloaked in fragrance, tufts  
of mossy step kiss the opening earth,  
a basement horizon presumes  
the darling test of flower  
across dale & rustling nook,  
then undresses moist greenery  
with sumptuous eye.

The last is hardest -  
cat crimson, a fire weed sunset lotion,  
the rain erased away;  
nobody special harangues the leaves  
but birds steal in quietly with  
tenderness clothed of verdure  
to pinch a leafy oasis about  
their forest haunt.

[\[35\]](#)

## PLUMS & VINE

Plums and vine (as the Atlantic is green)  
intone the heavy church wall  
with errant sprigs, so Heaven sent  
they are big with earthly passion  
racing for the sky.

Madonna Poverta in her midst  
with the pulpit clutching Light -  
so gnarled, like bush, that each crevice  
reeks with stone  
all stooped under such worldly avarice.

[\[36\]](#)

## PERHAPS

Perhaps the sky once was shadows,  
the moon lisped 'mongst April's song.  
Now, those warm lips ease  
departing sorrow  
like pressed flowers  
emptied from hallowed ground.

[\[37\]](#)

## APPROACHING THIRTY (Lauds and Matins)



Laconic tears or Botticelli's Venus  
holding the years  
like tresses  
in a wistful pose.

Tenebrous youth accosted  
by callow Time  
bleeds the heart  
with spring aloes.  
No comfortable shibboleths  
to restrain the wriggling polyps  
in the skin or nestling hair.

Gerundive in movement,  
each particled whimper  
of the clock surrounds  
a cloistered second  
poised about the bearded target.  
As far as you know, nothing unusual.

A total of eight hundred months  
but grammar school sums,  
spiel & mileage  
to drift across a lifetime.  
At thirty, the best half of the potage  
is gruel hand drawn from  
the sabulous pot.

[\[38\]](#).

## PASSAGEWAYS

Greet the days -  
greet the moon,  
gather the stars...

Man is not at one with himself -  
collars the infidel ways of his  
race under pressure domes of widening silence.

I scan the horizon barely cognizant  
of the metallic bits that pierce  
the night's crown - no  
jewelled orb stabs this queen's spectre.

I am running and lost. . . ever slow  
to breach this reasoning.

Honeysuckle mist with armfuls  
of orange lilies with scent stronger  
than the carriage needed in their gathering.

Place the constellations upon their heads,  
the colour so transcends.

And then there are the bludgeoned  
stars fallen into the eyes of  
my farmhouse scene.  
The sphinx moth that darns the night  
with her acrobatics escapes the wreath  
of troubled moon that places about  
her proboscised head.  
Let her stone the night in peace,  
feel palpitations on her ocean breast.

The darting of stone cracks in fissures  
along the causeway to the stonehouse  
is certain and sure.  
A definite mood projects  
the starling tunnels,  
forlorn now with limpid darkness,  
crushed lavender from the pews  
of thoughtful night.

There are armfuls of crushed bats  
in the passageway to my heart,  
each reeking with squeals  
to alarm the most frightened princess.  
Only one has stained the pass key  
and I must find her.

A toad abides the thoughtful recess  
broken under the wall.  
He is a good toad and mourns  
the night creaking from the river bed.  
A monster dragon to the insects  
making a living near the light -  
a source of amused contempt to lepidoptrists  
squeezing the eye's circle,  
pressing her to release her giddy charms.

At morning, skeletal remains  
shall stain the blighted chain (mood collector, toad, moth)

but, for now, only the night buzzes with alarm,  
cracking her secrets with each tiny monster  
hurled at light's intrusion into dark.

Perchance I shall narrow  
down the divide, position alarms,  
remind myself I am inured to the  
mood & scent that mans this cosmic bandwagon.  
I hold up flowers to remind me  
light escapes through jelly  
and that rare LUMINESCENCE exists only  
in lost bat chambers  
buried deep near the recesses  
of the snake.

The cry of havoc,  
all those armfuls of collapsed lilies  
breaking under the toil of enforced handshakes  
leaves me like a broken lamp.  
I have no more shades to patch  
the plinths or barricade my heart.  
I have left my love on bended knee  
in a land I choose to forget.

[\[39\]](#).

## KINDLING

As a matter of fact,  
ovens do carry a glazed stare,  
fireplaces are wont to parry  
thoughts to kindling  
before their stoop and  
on breathless summer nights  
one is hard pressed  
to recall cinder and  
blackened barleys any more  
vegetatively than upon  
these harridan pots.

[\[42\]](#).

# THE GLOWWORM

In slow sutures of pale white -  
dabbed in growing spume & mud dried earth,  
a glowworm is obliterated by warm, soft light  
coming up to elbow particles of near dappled clay  
that plants dissect, warm as feasts, aloft a muscat lawn.

Pale, segmented tortoise -  
trite in area and jellied purpose,  
the glowworm oozes headlong  
through an aroused dark  
necking furiously with fungus turds  
and truffles rooted from the  
pig ground by mice sized swine  
holidaying on scents and mildew salvaged  
thru pores & nestling bowels  
of their planet sized turf.

[\[43\]](#)

# BETWEEN TWO STONES

They poured hot water into people's cups  
in which green tea leaves were floating  
like algae,  
or into red-painted spittoons  
placed on the floor  
which the travellers made frequent use of...  
It was strangely quiet.

[\[44\]](#)

# THE WATERS OF THE BAY LIE BENEATH

An abandoned house -  
dark salved to eclectic;  
crinkly, black pigment of old pine boards  
disparate to the elements.

The waters of the bay lie beneath.  
A long slope trailing back of brush,  
garbles stones hoarse  
in the throat of a dust-flecked field  
are made more barren  
by the skunk cabbage weeds,  
the ugly, flotsam cloaks  
of horse hair to the neck -  
a hair shirt, coddling abrupt the barren pain  
tilled from empty soil.

The summer's heat.  
Nameless insect waifs  
wavering, adjusting tumult  
to straighten the tight air  
about the outward door frame.  
Pinched in windows, glass in  
refugee lots billowing about  
urine paper;  
nails a ruddy pick  
dried to rusty blue,  
some dim shiny in their cropped disrepair.  
A road dry, rotating bare,  
nameless zigzagged

only limestone in shelves  
meanders in  
throngs about stony debris,  
sometimes up to this beaten house.

[\[45\]](#).

## PASSING

I should be busy with words  
but light distracts me  
makes for me, in the sowing of its waves,  
neutral observances, a chilled awareness  
that the sublime is contained herein

the wonders of the commonplace.

[\[47\]](#).

## KITH AND KIN

Once there was a giant  
who lived in a kneecap,  
a peculiar giant at that  
who expelled all reality  
as a pig might a poke.

Not concerned with the dilemma  
of easing life's toothpaste form  
into dental crustings or  
oblivion's dark shadows  
from lightless paths,  
the giant assumed guardianship  
over his fibro-tissual home.

The giant could be seen  
ferrying dwarfed bones  
over the inter causal dome  
of flesh and blood.

At times, he substituted  
a remarkable likeness  
for his kith and kin  
by dumping calloused cushions,  
too long cousins  
of the diaper rash effect  
bunions, corns,  
carbuncles  
eager to roam  
the padlocked sockets  
between distant fibula  
and tibia.

Poor femur, of course, was  
outraged against carpals  
and the growing phalanx  
arrangement of  
distant phalanges.  
Even the metatarsals

were girdled in  
righteous indignation  
committed against their person  
by a maverick masquerading  
in pelvic insubordination.

Altogether the body contains 206 bones.  
It is rumoured none contain  
a giant of his capacity, notoriety, or effect.

[\[48\]](#).

## TO SIT ARRAYED

To sit arrayed  
and task consumed  
by the edge of a window,  
the world as fire  
stepping free of winter's stain,  
jutting fingers of light  
to a basement ledge  
then allowing their  
foggy movement to  
displace dust's circle  
as it has come  
to be known  
over the last  
five months,  
is to come as  
near as possible  
to the brink  
of private  
sanity.

[\[50\]](#).

## SILVER COINS

Seen the whores in doorsteps,  
slack, crouched as packing crates  
behind their quiet wardrobe lamps,  
inset like a skeleton's crown  
there to bend our will,  
provide passageways to power and suggestion;  
the winding entrance to rouged  
light flickering with powdered flesh  
yellow of gold,  
then black to ivory  
a frightful circus in a palace of turn  
within the grate of execution.

[\[51\]](#).

## SENTRY

In Edvard Munch's painting, The Scream, eyes  
are grouped as discs, almost rotund arches,  
much as suns breaking over an eclipsed wall.  
Hollows, jittery the bridge a creamed escape  
careening the soul madly backward  
a pastel gathering sky -  
water rivulets where two solitary, graven figures  
seem indulging a flaccid, breaking stream.

[\[52\]](#).

## THE POTATO EATERS

The potato eaters -  
grim, weathered souls  
wrenching a meal  
from sandy waste.

The dark toil lined ridges  
carried from their fields  
to each human face,  
dim, pale light  
as shadowy as



lives eked out upon this stoney rash of soil.

Brows, a murky legend  
of overwork -  
deflected hope,  
seasons up in the smoke  
of a potato boil.

[\[53\]](#).

## THE ASSIGNATION (PONS ASINORUM)

Many devils are in woods, in waters, in wilderness and in dark,  
pooly places ready to hurt. . . people, some are also in thick,  
black clouds. Martin Luther

. . . Masaccio to the Florentine Renaissance but a naught-  
every man the same, St. Francis the same as a Jack the Ripper.  
their rosy surfaces filled.

Like an Old Testament curse  
he is loosed upon the earth.  
Ecking out his pound of flesh  
delivering misery in sordidness, he parboils the land.

A modern day Tantalus up to his throat  
in burning lies,  
his death is to live, in the contemporary sense,  
the thousand cuts-  
to bury the skies as a dread Caiaphas  
into the contradiction, the snares of his being.

Measure for measure  
his blond mane, pale scarf  
are hallmarks of the doomed Dutchman searching out the  
Coromandel;  
like Cain stumbling upon existence,  
he hearkens back to the original Murderer,  
has sold his inheritance for a pittance  
and by doing so has ridiculed the human condition  
with his life charged obscenity;

his blond beast scowl curdled about respectability's neck,  
his fang tussled face a menacing white cigarette,  
the soul imprisoned jailer to his teeth, breath and brain.

[\[54\]](#)

## HAUNTED CHILD

In the dark of wedlock  
nightly sky,  
the wither of hope  
and estranged replies,  
cause a white face to flicker  
with transparent eye,  
calumny of purpose  
to slowly die.

[\[55\]](#)

## TRIANGULAR TRADE

I would watch him lifting  
another drink from the fridge,  
joke about the connection  
with a triangular trade -  
bedroom to kitchen fridge,  
then to the bathroom -  
only to repeat the cycle  
not knowing such comments  
scratched his eyes  
climbing through the window  
for escape.

[\[56\]](#)

## CASTING ROCKS

Merely on edge,  
the wharf in bad light  
clinging to water's ledge -  
a loon from afar  
the Woods  
closing with each sound.

Casting rocks toward moon's glare  
lapidations laughing back,  
the treacle of warm night  
coaxing fire's glowing might.

Sudden, oceanic wilderness  
breathless in barked silence -  
and camphor to keep the flies at distance,  
the anchored boat like a prison ship  
dallying on the waves,  
brambles & underbrush  
sunken wet sand,  
abundant berries rasp in thickets -  
the cottage like a jar  
closing for the night.

[\[57\]](#)

## BRUSHSTROKE

On rue Vincingetorix,  
a Paris hovel  
in a garret of cold -  
Gauguin enchanted  
serpentine colours, the medium of  
a brushstroke from  
a paltry primitivism.

Rue Vincingetorix,  
cloudy haze  
sun as billowing plaster,  
neatly laps  
scrapes clean  
the bereavement  
of a man's pain.

[\[58\]](#)

## MAN

In the old air  
by his rocker,  
a silent trapeze of thought  
suspends an aging man.

Each movement as of the katydid  
droning -  
a monologue with the past;  
a buzz escaping across  
still, warm air.  
Elsewhere, cicadas whittle about the octogenarian heat.  
Nestled quietly, a supine stare erodes both time & place  
unto bearded grey -  
nuances clasped  
in a breathless chat with death.

[\[59\]](#)

## LANDING SCHEMES

Omens are the cloth of dreams  
scissors used to open sky -  
the future riding birds  
en route to ariel docking piles.

Leonardo was of the opinion creativity might be  
enhanced a notch should aspiring artists nota bene  
principalities, bile, their rhumes as tiles  
then perceive them piecemeal as stratagem, not snuff or  
random blotch, the heads of diseased pigs  
but conjuror-sextants toward the stars.

[\[60\]](#)

# MIRAGE

The intense focus of light  
but pointillism,  
into this juncture bits of light  
surround rough, inverted sky -  
dawn is their message  
unfurled about  
the alumni apparatus  
of incensed eyes  
and whispered sun.

The heavy mirage of dots,  
landscape locked  
Seurat, a frieze of summer heat  
choking water lilies -  
the sun as a crystal ship  
adrift across  
bedlam-sponsored  
random dots.

[\[61\]](#).

# STONE GUIDE

She was fading -  
into the stone  
into rifled shadows heavy  
with fallen light,  
rippled boughs  
of splitting fruit &  
droopy leaves  
to a sallow body under clumsy years  
that ripped the tunic of her coat  
while bleating the dismal age  
with each petal fall  
of a stockinged foot.

[\[62\]](#).

## RED ILLUSIONS UNDER GLASS

Life as green illusion -  
the cool fronds of the fern  
are deep set in firmest soil  
and the grassy narrows  
brook a silent, liquid play.

Red illusions under glass -  
quietly picking strawberries  
where a woman hums to  
the buzz of flies  
with the afternoon sun disappearing overhead.

Each grasp of the berry  
a red stain, the darting of seeds,  
crimson tendrils do confuse the eye  
with a polka dot starling raucous  
in glee above.

[\[63\]](#).

**English born, Paul Cameron Brown has lived in or around the Toronto area for most of his thirty years.**

**His poems have appeared in periodicals across Canada and into the United States.**

**One previous book, *Whispers*, appeared in 1977.**



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